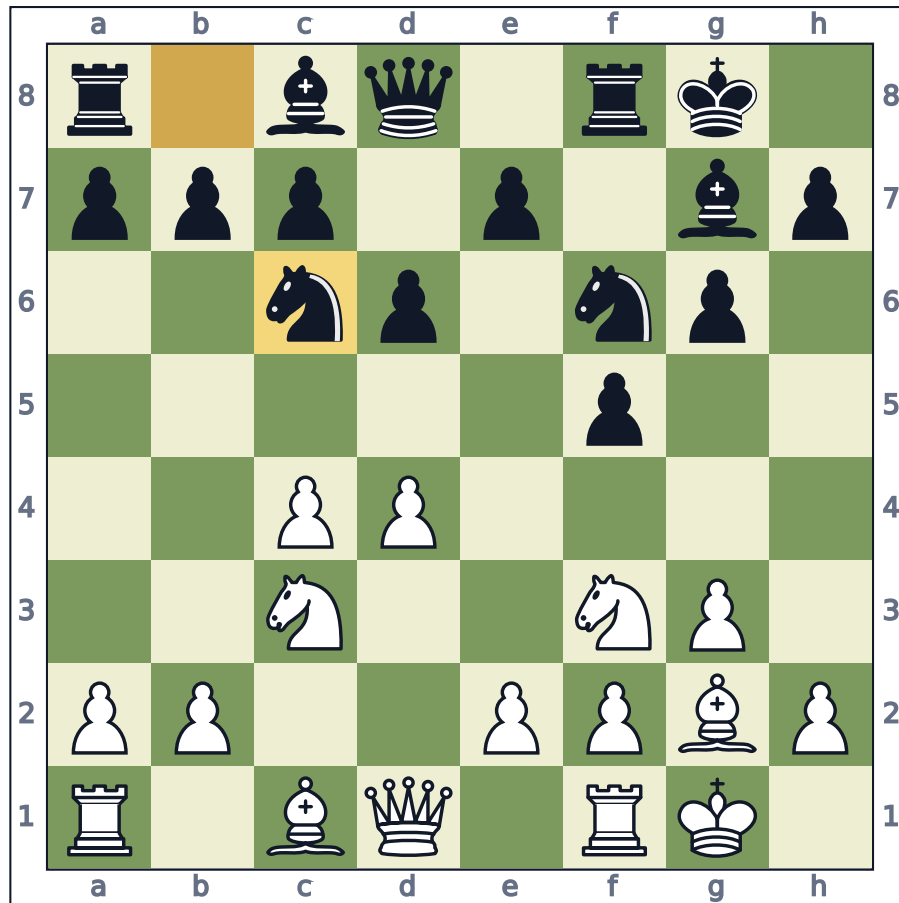


Dutch Defense

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BLACK FOCUS

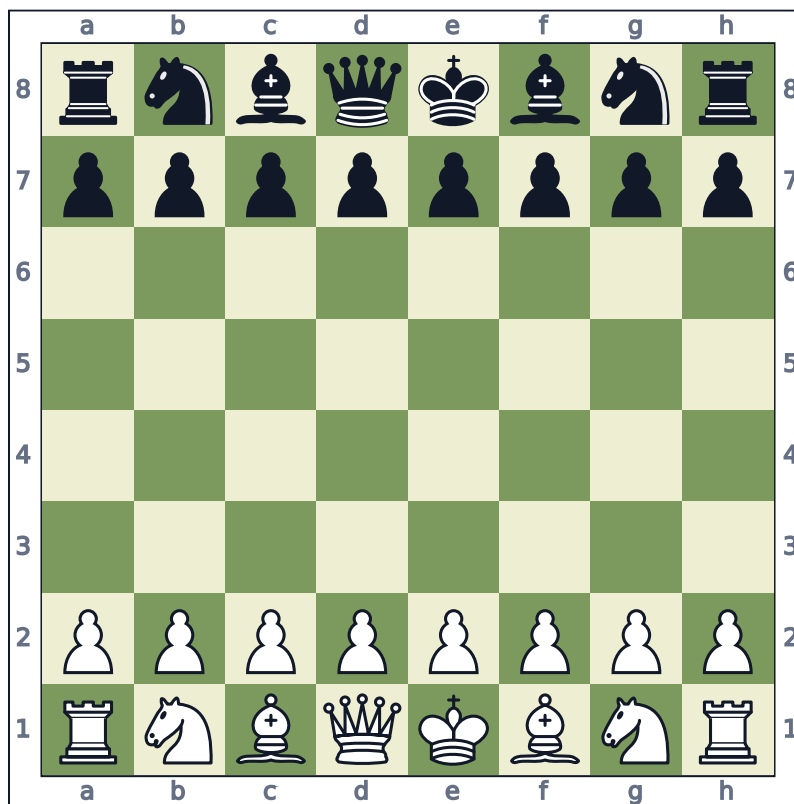
OPENING IDENTITY

Black controls e4 with the f-pawn and accepts kingside looseness for active play.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

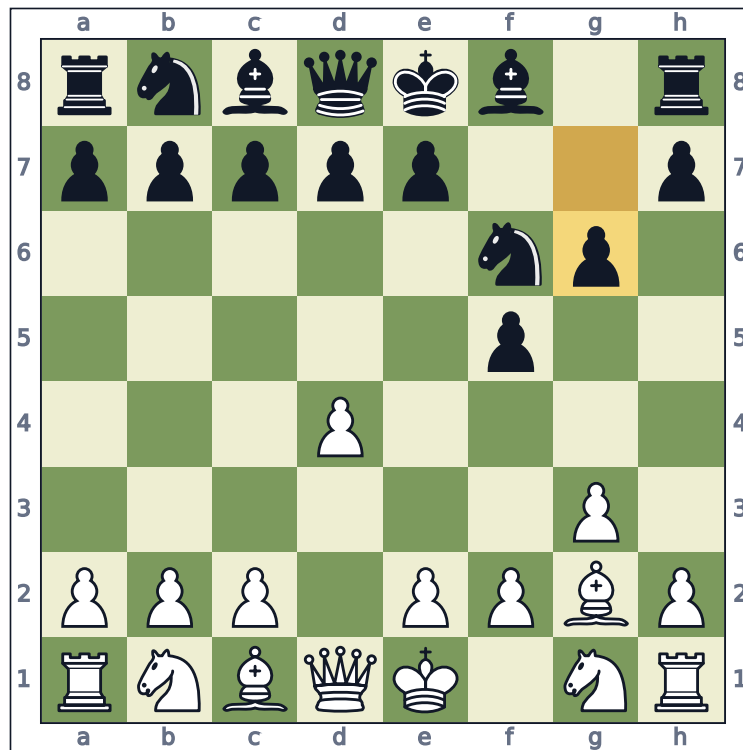
1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6

Course promise: Control e4, then justify the loosened kingside.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6



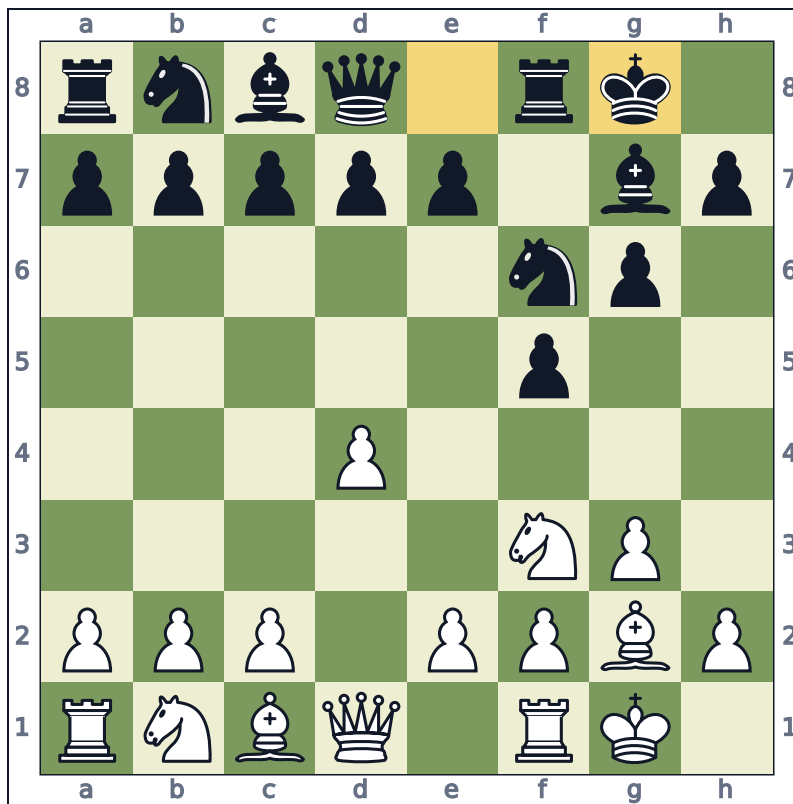
After 3. Bg2 g6

- 1. d4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... f5 - Creates a lever against the center or supports a coming break.
- 2. g3 - Gains wing space, but also changes squares that can no longer be protected by this pawn.
- 2... Nf6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3. Bg2 - Develops on an active diagonal, often adding a pin or long-range pressure.
- 3... g6 - Gains wing space, but also changes squares that can no longer be protected by this pawn.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. O-O O-O



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Black controls e4 with the f-pawn and accepts kingside looseness for active play.

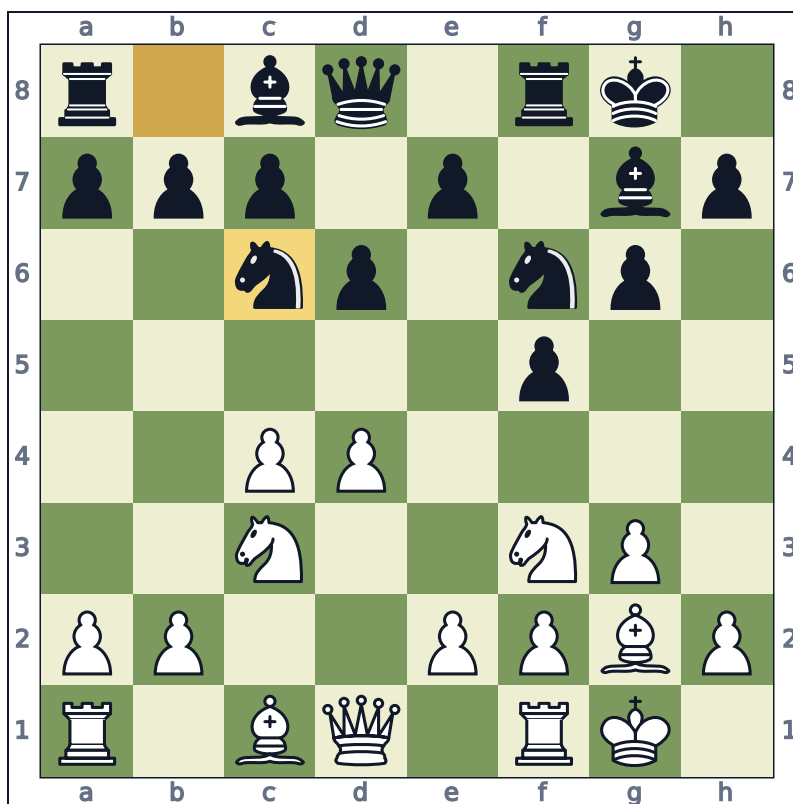
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. d4 f5 2. g3 Nf6 3. Bg2 g6 4. Nf3 Bg7 5. O-O O-O 6. c4 d6 7. Nc3 Nc6



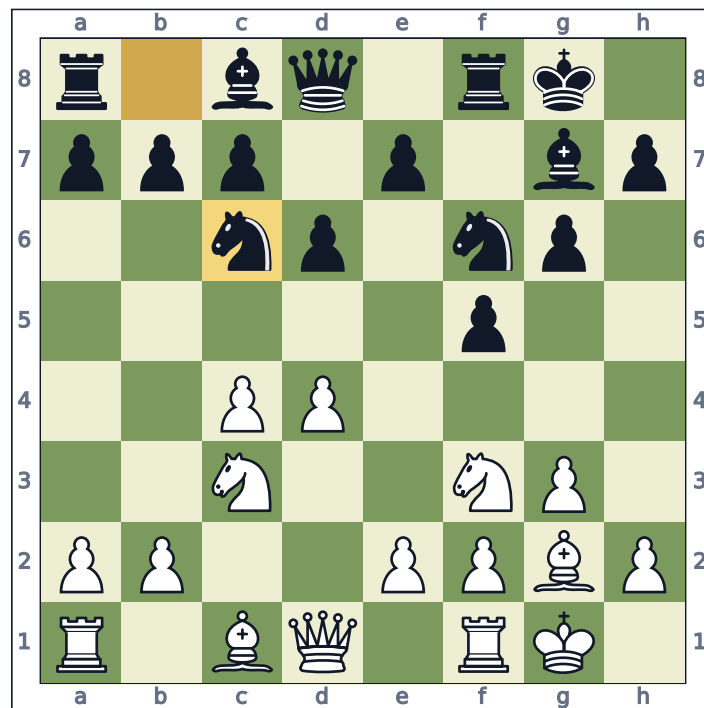
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Black controls e4 with the f-pawn and accepts kingside looseness for active play. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Pressure the dark squares, use e4 when prepared, and exploit any weak king diagonals.

BLACK'S PLAN

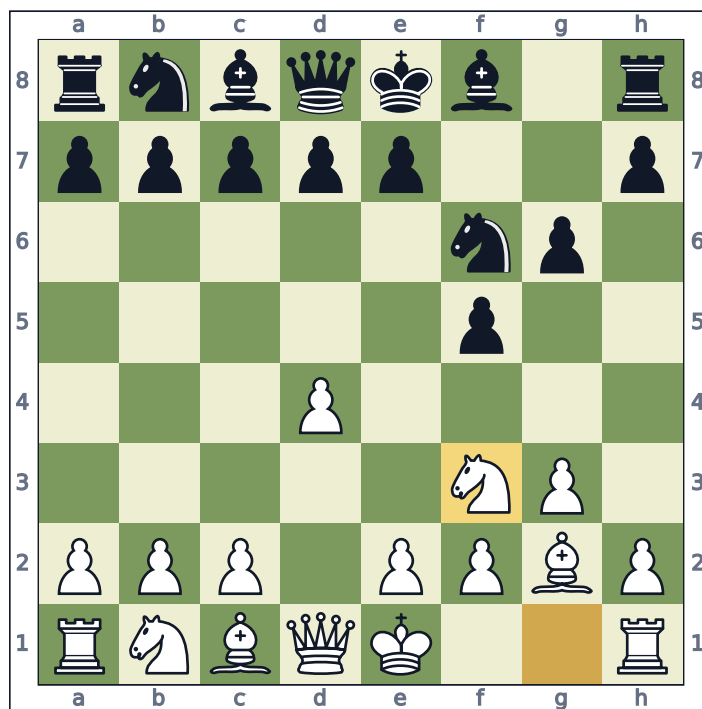
Build around e4, complete development, and choose ...e5 or queenside support according to the setup.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

...e5 is the thematic central break; White often answers with d5 or e4.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - Black to move

THEME

The diagonal toward h5 and the weakened e6-square can matter after an early ...f5.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

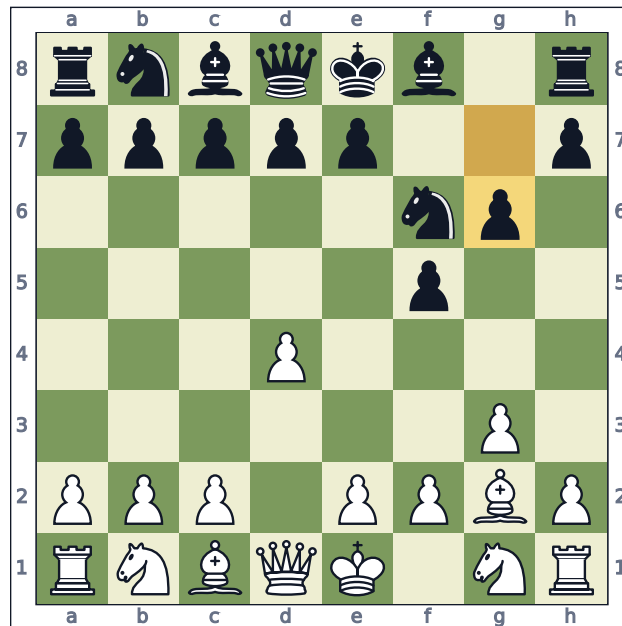
Pushing ...f5 and ...g5 without making the king safe.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Black controls e4 with the f-pawn and accepts kingside looseness for active play.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: ...e5 is the thematic central break; White often answers with d5 or e4.

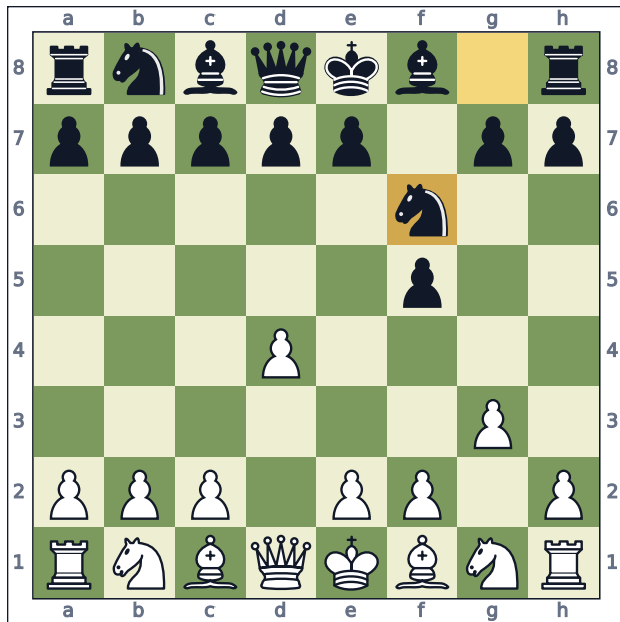
MEMORY SENTENCE

Control e4, then justify the loosened kingside.

ACTIVE RECALL

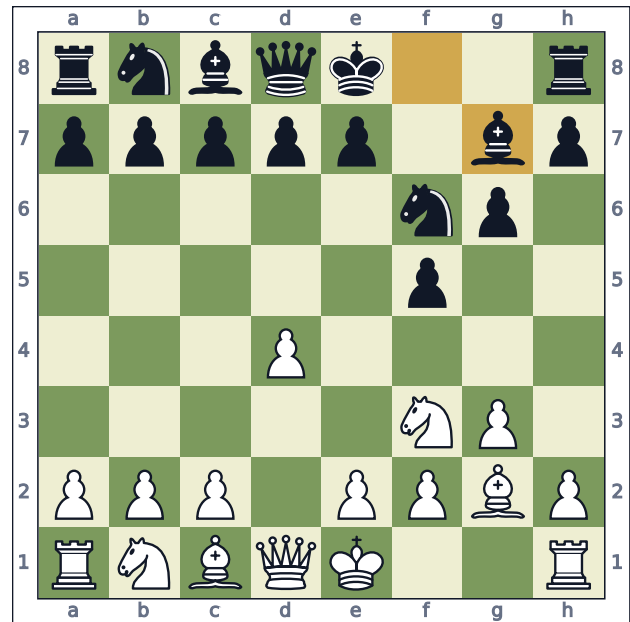
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Bg2. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: O-O. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Pressure the dark squares, use e4 when prepared, and exploit any weak king diagonals. Black: Build around e4, complete development, and choose ...e5 or queenside support according to the setup. Lever: ...e5 is the thematic central break; White often answers with d5 or e4.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.